



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON: CHORD EXTENSIONS & SUBSTITUTIONS

Introduction: Elevating Your Chord Vocabulary

Chord extensions and substitutions are advanced harmonic techniques that can add depth and color to your playing. They take basic chords (like triads and seventh chords) and transform them into richer, more complex harmonic structures. By understanding and applying chord extensions and substitutions, you'll be able to create more interesting progressions, add nuance to your rhythm playing, and open up new possibilities in improvisation and songwriting.

In this lesson, we'll explore what chord extensions and substitutions are, how they're built, and when to use them to enhance your music.

What are Chord Extensions?

Chord extensions are notes added to a basic chord structure (usually a triad or seventh chord) that extend beyond the octave of the root note. These additional notes create new harmonic colors and textures.

Basic chord structure:

- **Triad:** Root, 3rd, and 5th.
- **Seventh chord:** Root, 3rd, 5th, and 7th.

Chord extensions add additional notes, such as the 9th, 11th, and 13th, which can be derived from the corresponding scale of the chord.

Common Chord Extensions and Their Intervals:

1. **9th:** Adds the 9th note of the scale (2nd note an octave higher).
 - Example: Cmaj9 (C, E, G, B, D).
2. **11th:** Adds the 11th note of the scale (4th note an octave higher).
 - Example: Cmaj11 (C, E, G, B, D, F).
3. **13th:** Adds the 13th note of the scale (6th note an octave higher).
 - Example: Cmaj13 (C, E, G, B, D, F, A).

Note: When adding extensions, it's common to omit some notes from the basic chord (usually the 5th) to make the voicing easier to play and less cluttered.



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How to Construct Chord Extensions

To build chord extensions, start with a basic triad or seventh chord and add notes according to the desired extension.

1. Start with a Seventh Chord:

- Example: Cmaj7 = C (Root), E (3rd), G (5th), B (7th).

2. Add the 9th, 11th, or 13th:

- Cmaj9: C, E, G, B, D (9th).
- Cmaj11: C, E, G, B, D, F (11th).
- Cmaj13: C, E, G, B, D, F, A (13th).

3. Create Voicings That Omit Certain Notes:

- Due to the physical constraints of the guitar, you may need to omit the 5th or even the root to make the chord more playable.
- Example: Cmaj9 can be played as (E, B, D) on the guitar.

How Chord Extensions Affect the Sound:

- **9th chords** add brightness and a sense of openness.
- **11th chords** add a suspended, dreamy quality.
- **13th chords** add warmth and richness.

By incorporating these extensions, your chords will sound more sophisticated and less predictable.

What are Chord Substitutions?

Chord substitutions involve replacing one chord with another that serves a similar harmonic function. This technique can be used to create smoother transitions, add harmonic variety, and surprise the listener.

Common Types of Chord Substitutions:

1. Relative Minor and Major Substitution:

- Replace a major chord with its relative minor, or vice versa.
- Example: Replace C major with A minor (since A minor is the relative minor of C major).

2. Diatonic Substitution:

- Replace a chord with another chord from the same key.



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- Example: Replace Cmaj7 with Em7 in the key of C major (Em7 is the iii chord in C major).

3. Tritone Substitution:

- Replace a dominant 7th chord with another dominant 7th chord that is a tritone away.
- Example: Replace G7 with Db7 (Db is a tritone away from G).

4. Chromatic Substitution:

- Replace a chord with another chord that is chromatically a half-step away.
- Example: Replace Fmaj7 with Emaj7 or Gbmaj7 for a chromatic approach.

When and How to Use Chord Substitutions

1. Adding Variety to Progressions:

- Instead of repeating the same chord progression, use substitutions to add harmonic interest.
- Example: In a I-IV-V progression in C (C-F-G), replace G with E7 (a secondary dominant leading to A minor).

2. Creating Smooth Voice Leading:

- Substitutions help create smoother transitions between chords.
- Example: Replace G7 (V) with Bm7b5 (vii7b5) when resolving to Cmaj7, as Bm7b5 naturally leads to Cmaj7.

3. Improvisation and Comping:

- Use substitutions to provide harmonic support and unexpected turns during comping or soloing.
- Example: Use Abmaj7 as a chromatic passing chord when moving from G7 to Cmaj7.

Exercises for Practicing Chord Extensions and Substitutions

Exercise 1: Building Extended Chords

1. Start with a C major triad (C, E, G).
2. Add the 7th (B) to form Cmaj7.
3. Add the 9th (D), 11th (F), and 13th (A) one at a time.



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4. Play the chord in different positions on the neck.

Exercise 2: Practicing Substitutions in Common Progressions

1. Take a standard I-IV-V progression (e.g., C-F-G).
2. Substitute G with its relative minor (Em).
3. Substitute F with Dm (ii chord in C major).
4. Experiment with more advanced substitutions (e.g., use E7 to replace G7).

Exercise 3: Substitution Practice with Tritones

1. Choose a dominant 7th chord (e.g., G7).
2. Find its tritone (D $\flat$ 7) and play it in place of G7.
3. Practice resolving D $\flat$ 7 back to the tonic (Cmaj7) to hear the smooth resolution.

Exercise 4: Creating Voicings for Extended Chords

1. Build a chord progression using only extended chords (e.g., Cmaj9, Fmaj9, G13).
2. Play through the progression in different positions to internalize the shapes and sounds.